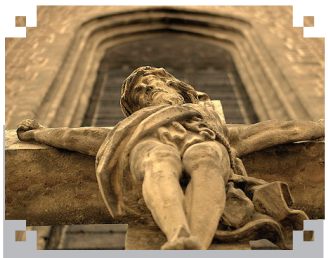
Sentinels of the Dawn

Newsletter of the Poor Clares of Perpetuelle Adoration

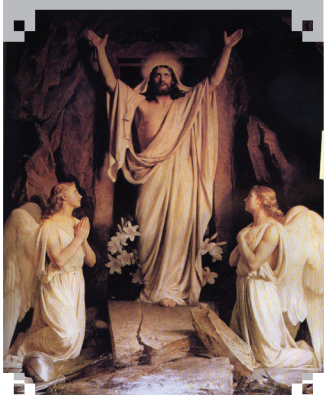
Monastère Notre Dame des Anges Troyes, France

Easter 2009 Volume 5



If you have been raised with Christ, seek the things that are above, where Christ is seated at the right hand of God.

Col. 3:1-2



Resurrection and Mission

In different Gospel accounts, we read of Jesus' appearances after His glorious Resurrection to Mary Magdalene at the tomb, to the two disciples on the road to Emmaus, to the disciples at the Sea of Tiberias, to the Eleven gathered together behind locked doors for fear of the Jews, and finally to Thomas, the disciple who refused to believe.

Why did Jesus not go in triumph to the Pharisees or to Pilate and those who put Him to death? Why did He not show them that He was alive and let them touch His scars as He did with Thomas? Why does the Resurrected Jesus choose to reveal Himself only to a few and not to all? Perhaps the answer is found in the mission of Christ Himself, who three years earlier had chosen them for a purpose. Most of them failed to understand Christ's mission, abandoning Him when His hour had come. After His death, they were uncertain, flooded with sorrow and doubt. To strengthen their wavering faith, to quell their fear, to help them to embrace the mission for which He had chosen them, even to the point of shedding their blood, He appears to them, and each time in a special way.

Peter, for example, prior to Jesus' death openly denied Him, but after the Resurrection, we see in the Acts of the Apostles how his faith in Christ's Resurrection gave him the courage to boldly proclaim Jesus as Christ to all those around him. The power of the Resurrection transformed Peter from the inside out. Love cast out his fear. He became a transformed person, on fire with love. Today, this transformation can happen in each one of us. We are invited to cooperate with the transforming grace of God in our own life experiences as well.

This transforming grace of God through the power of His Resurrection is experienced when we ask forgiveness, when we offer solace and comfort to someone who is suffering, when we are faithful to our responsibilities, when we are willing to "make waves" in order to promote what is just and right. The Resurrection of Jesus is experienced when we live in hope, when addictions are overcome, when relationships are reconciled. Each day provides us with occasions to participate more fully in His glorious Resurrection.

May the Resurrected Lord continue to touch us with His presence. May His presence increase our conviction of His victory over death. May His Resurrected presence continue to draw us outwards into the unknown, the beyond, the infinite, the Eternal. May we move forward with confidence because Jesus has gone ahead of us.

Have confiance, He is calling you!



This year's theme for World Day of Prayer for Vocations on May 3rd, invites us to meditate on the encounter between Jesus and Bartimeus. Plunged in darkness, this blind beggar is sitting on the side of the road when Jesus passes by. Scripture tells us that he cries out to Jesus, not once but twice, despite those among him trying to keep him quiet. Then, Jesus calls the man to Himself. Perhaps Bartimeus "sees" at this point that alone he can do nothing, but is hopeful that Jesus can help him. With great faith in Jesus, Bartimeus at once throws off his mantle, jumps up and runs to Jesus. Leaving behind everything, he makes haste to respond to the call of Jesus. Jesus asks what He can do for the man. The blind beggar responds to this invitation, "Master, let me see again." (Mark 10:51) Immediately, his request is granted. He receives his sight and the Gospel account ends with him following Jesus along the road, a road that leads to Jerusalem, where He will be handed over to death.

What does it mean to "follow Jesus"? Externally, we can choose to follow Jesus, going through the motions, but if we do not heed the voice of the Good Shepherd, we will not advance, nor persevere. Following Christ requires an interior response as well. When we follow Christ, we take a new direction; our selfish wishes and desires are no longer our main focus; Christ is.

To follow means to go behind, to move in the direction prescribed, even amidst the difficulties which may arise from time to time. Following is entrusting our life to Christ, confident that He will lead us to the truth, where at last we will be happy.

There is a Bartimeus in all of us. At one time or another, we have all experienced darkness or uncertainty about the meaning of our life. And then Jesus comes to enlighten the way. Like Bartimeus, like the Twelve apostles, like so many saints who have followed in the footsteps of Christ, let us respond wholeheartedly when He calls.

Let us pray for the youth, who are confronted with so many challenges, who have to make difficult decisions. May they recognize Christ's loving presence at their side, may they not be afraid to ask Him for help in their time of need. May they follow Him wholeheartedly along the path that leads to true life.

Congratulations to the 36 newly baptised of our diocese



Each year our Bishop, Marc Stenger, entrusts the catechumens of the diocese who will be baptised at Easter to a different religious community. This year our Community was asked to spiritually accompany them in their journey of faith. A scroll with the names of 36 catechumens was presented to us by the Bishop, which we placed before the statue of Our Lady of Lourdes in our chapel. The Mass was also offered for them and their intention each Sunday during Lent, as well as the Easter Vigil Mass, the night of their initation into the Church.

We give thanks to God for all the newly baptised and we continue to prayerfully support them. We pray that the seed of faith planted in their hearts will grow and flourish, that they will be witnesses of the Gospel through their words and actions.

«All of you who were baptised in Christ, have clothed yourselves with Christ.» Gal 3:27

Come and See the Works of the Lord

We are always happy to welcome visitors to the monastery, especially young people who are interested in knowing more about our contemplative life as adorers of the Most Blessed Sacrament. For the past two years, students from Cité Aviat, a private school run by the Sister Oblates of Saint Francis de Sales, have come to visit us.

A little presentation on the history of our Order was prepared for our visitors, followed by a slide show, which visually enabled them to better understand our cloistered, contemplative life, one which is hidden from the eyes of the world. A time of questions and answers gave them an opportunity to satisfy their curiosity and shed light on certain doubts or misunderstandings they previously had before they were introduced to our community.





We in turn received much from these groups of energetic youth. Their openness and sincerity in seeking the truth touched our hearts. We give thanks for these times of sharing which proved to be fruitful, and we look forward to the next gathering with them.



A Surprise Visitor



It's not too often that one has the occasion to receive the "traveling"relics of a saint, but this very special privilege was granted to us during the Easter Octave. From the evening of April 16th to the afternoon of the following day, the relics of St. Margaret Mary Alacoque remained in our chapel for public veneration.

Since 2002, the relics of this French nun of the Order of the Visitation have travelled to different parts of the world. Father Eduoard Marot, chaplain of the Sancutary of Paray-le-Monial, is responsible for making this event possible. It has carried with it a message of love and hope for all God's people. Throughout the course of these travels, several different countries have consecrated themselves to the Sacred Heart of Jesus in the presence of the relics of this saint.

We are very grateful to Mother Françoise-Romaine Vilchair, Prioress of the Visitation monastery in Troyes, for her generosity and thoughtfulness, in offering our community the rare opportunity to receive the relics of this saint, whose mission was to promote devotion to the Sacred Heart of Jesus. May all come to know and experience His Divine Love, and return love for Love.



Saint Margaret Mary, pray for us!



THE GREAT ESCAPE

In past issues of our newsletter, our guard dog, Ma Belle, has been featured. It seems that she has quite a few "admirers" among our readers, so we thought you might enjoy hearing about one of her latest adventures.

Like most dogs, Ma Belle's daily routine consists of eating, sleeping, finding the perfect spot to spread out and enjoy the passing hours of the day under the warm rays of Brother Sun. Occasionally, she finds it necessary to bark when visitors ring the doorbell and even to station herself at the entrance door to make her presence known. As in most cases, Ma Belle's bark is "worse than her bite", and a simple caress or even a treat is certain to win over her heart. She is very observant and unfortunately is always on the look out for occasions to escape!

Such was the case one afternoon when Sr. Germaine, a Sister Oblate of St. Francis de Sales, had just finished giving our Sisters their French lesson. One of them accompanied Sr: Germaine to the door, and Ma Belle seized the opportunity to make her way into the hallway. Before Sister could do anything to stop her, Ma Belle snuck past her, out the front door, and out of the confines of the cloister. Perhaps a bit intimidated by the broad, unknown horizon opening out before her, she simply followed Sr. Germaine all the way back to her convent. A short time later, we received a phone call from Sr. Germaine confirming Ma Belle's whereabouts and her safety within the property of the Sister's convent.



While some of us concluded that Ma Belle simply wanted to protect Sr. Germaine on her return home, others thought perhaps Ma Belle wanted to pay a visit to her cousin, Twinkie, the Sister Oblates' dog. In any case, she seemed perfectly content to return to her *stomping grounds* for her afternoon siesta.

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Jubilee Year for Priests



In commemorating the 150th anniversary of the death of the Cure of Ars, Saint John Mary Vianney, the Holy Father recently announced that a special year for priests will be celebrated from June 19th, 2009 to June 19th, 2010. The particular theme for this year will be: *Faithfulness of Christ, Faithfulness of Priests.*

During this jubilee year, Pope Benedict XVI will proclaim John Mary Vianney Patron of all priests in the world. Let us remember to pray in a special way for all priests this year, in particular our Bishop and those of our diocese. Each day they minister to the needs of the members of Christ's body, the Church. They nourish the faithful through the Word of God and the Holy Eucharist, as well as the other sacraments. May God grant them strength and courage to continue in their mission of bringing the light of God's truth and love to the world and to lead all along the path of holiness. We entrust them and all seminarians who are preparing for the Holy Priesthood to the maternal care of Mary, Mother of the Church.